

Stellaris Modlist Guide

A Curated, Beginner-Friendly Modding
Companion

Version 0.1 — 2026

Stellaris (all DLC) • Windows • Mod Organizer 2

Stellaris Modlist Guide

Welcome to the **Stellaris Modlist Guide** — a curated, three-wave curriculum for learning Stellaris through modded playthroughs.

This guide is written for **complete beginners** who want to learn the game while enjoying a balanced modlist. No prior experience required.

The Three-Wave Curriculum

Instead of installing every mod at once and hoping for the best, this guide breaks your journey into **three complete playthroughs (waves)**. Each wave uses a different mod set, a different empire, and harder difficulty settings. You start fresh each time — and each time, you learn more.

Wave	Difficulty	Empire	Origin	Mod Focus
1: The Horizon Seekers	Beginner	Fanatic Egalitarian + Materialist	Scion (<i>Federations</i> DLC)	Cosmetic & QoL — learn vanilla with better UI
2: The Eternal Legion	Intermediate	Authoritarian + Militarist + Spiritualist	Remnants (<i>Federations</i> DLC)	Gameplay — smarter AI, deeper warfare & economy
3: The Unshackled	Expert	Fanatic Militarist + Materialist	Payback (<i>First Contact</i> DLC)	Full content — all mods, maximum depth

Every mod in the [Modlist](#) is tagged with the wave it belongs to (1+, 2+, 3, or all waves). You install only what you need for where you are.

What You'll Find Here

- **Getting Started** — Stellaris fundamentals: galaxy setup, basic mechanics, diplomacy, war, economy
- **Modlist Setup** — How to install Mod Organizer 2, download mods, and version-lock them
- **The Waves** — The curriculum. Start here and play through in order.
- **The Modlist** — Complete reference of ~60-120 curated mods organized by category, each tagged by wave
- **Load Order** — How to arrange mods with MO2 visual separators

- **Starting a Game** — General reference for empire creation and galaxy settings
- **Performance** — Empirical FPS and load time benchmarks
- **Missing Mods (Research)** — Wishlist for custom mod development
- **Appendix** — Glossary, troubleshooting, credits

Version

Guide version **0.1** — Stellaris **4.4.6 "Nomads"** (all DLC), Windows.

Principles

- **No cheating or overpower mods** — every mod here respects game balance
- **Beginner-first** — terms explained, no acronyms assumed
- **Version discipline** — mod versions are locked to prevent mid-campaign breakage
- **Progressive complexity** — each wave adds mechanics only when you're ready for them

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Getting Started with Stellaris

Guide: *If you've never launched Stellaris, start here. This section teaches you what the game is, how it works, and what you need to know before your first session.*

What Kind of Game Is This?

Stellaris is a **grand strategy 4X game** — Explore, Expand, Exploit, Exterminate — set in space. It's **real-time with pause**: the galaxy keeps moving, but you can freeze time at any moment to issue orders, read tooltips, and think through decisions. You control the pace entirely through the speed slider.

A single campaign takes 20-40 hours and spans **300 in-game years** (2200–2500). Your civilization starts with a single planet and one science ship. Where it ends is up to you.

Choosing Your Empire

This is the most important decision you'll make. Your empire is defined by four layers.

Ethics

Ethics are your civilization's core values. They come in pairs of opposites — you pick one side of each pair, or stay neutral in the middle. There are **three axes**:

Axis	Ethic A	Ethic B
Society	Egalitarian — individual rights, utopian abundance, specialists are stronger	Authoritarian — stratified society, rulers are stronger, slavery allowed
Economy	Militarist — strong military, cheaper claims, stronger armies	Pacifist — diplomatic bonuses, less war exhaustion, stability bonus
Diplomacy	Xenophile — likes aliens, better diplomacy, more envoys, migration pacts	Xenophobe — dislikes aliens, cheaper starbases, purge allowed, population happiness bonus
Technology	Materialist — more tech output, robots allowed, synthetic ascension	Spiritualist — more unity, psionic ascension, temple buildings
Governance	—	Gestalt Consciousness — hivemind or machine intelligence, no factions, no trade, no happiness

Beginners should pick: Egalitarian + Materialist + Xenophile (a "good guy" science-focused empire). This is simple to play: make friends, research fast, stay out of trouble.

Authority

Authority is **how your leader is chosen** and determines some unique mechanics.

Authority	How Leaders Work	Unique Mechanic
Democratic	Elections every 10 years, you can support a candidate with campaign funds	Mandates: complete a goal during your leader's term for bonus unity
Oligarchic	Elections every 40 years, choose from 3 candidates	Factions have more influence on policy
Dictatorial	Leader rules for life, successor chosen on death	Strong leader bonuses, stable
Imperial	Hereditary ruler, dynasty continues on death	Heir system, very stable
Gestalt Consciousness	No elections, the "hive mind" is the leader	No factions, no trade, can't do first-contact diplomacy normally

For your first game: Pick **Democratic** or **Imperial**. They're simple and forgiving.

Origin

Origins are your empire's **starting situation and backstory**. Some start on a different planet type, some begin with advanced technology, some face unique challenges. Origins are **locked at game start** — you cannot change them.

Beginner-friendly origins:

Origin	What It Does	Why It's Good
Prosperous Unification	Start with extra pops and a developed homeworld	Well-rounded, no gimmicks, strongest economy turn 1
Mechanist	Start with robotic workers researched + two robot pops	Robots work everywhere, good for materialist empires
Syncretic Evolution	Two subspecies: one intelligent, one strong + rapid breeding	The worker species handles basic jobs while your main species does science
Lost Colony	Your homeworld is Earth. Sol will be somewhere in the galaxy	Cool narrative hook, +opinion with humans
Scion	You start as a vassal of a Fallen Empire	A superpower protects you — very forgiving

Avoid for your first game: Doomsday (your planet explodes), Void Dweller (you start on habitats — complex), Here Be Dragons (distracting), any origin that changes basic mechanics.

Species Traits

Traits are your species' biological characteristics. You have a **point budget** — positive traits cost points, negative traits refund them.

Efficient beginner picks:

- **Intelligent** (+10% research speed) — research is king
- **Rapid Breeders** (+10% pop growth) — pops are everything
- **Adaptive** (+10% habitability) — more colonizable planets
- **Enduring** (+20 leader lifespan) — leaders don't die as fast

Newbie trap traits to avoid:

- **Decadent** (requires slaves or specialists get unhappy) — micro-heavy
- **Non-Adaptive** (fewer habitable planets) — slows expansion
- **Solitary** (lower housing usage, lower happiness from amenities) — sounds good but the happiness penalty hurts

Civics

Civics are your empire's **governmental policies** and specializations. You choose two at game start (some origins grant a third).

Easy beginner civics:

Civic	What It Does	Best With
Meritocracy	Specialist jobs (+10% output) based on skill, not birth	Egalitarian, Democratic
Technocracy	Ruler jobs also produce research	Materialist
Mining Guilds	Miners produce extra minerals and also produce some alloys	Any expansionist build
Efficient Bureaucracy	Fewer empire sprawl from pops	Any
Functional Architecture	Cheaper buildings, extra building slot	Any — simple and effective

Resources – The Economy

Stellaris has **9 basic resources** organized into three tiers:

Tier 1: Raw Resources

Resource	Produced By	Used For
Energy Credits	Generator Districts, trade	Upkeep for ships, starbases, leaders, and pops. Also the galactic currency.
Minerals	Mining Districts	Building construction, districts, consumer goods, alloys
Food	Agriculture Districts	Feeding your population. Surplus = pop growth bonus.

Tier 2: Refined Resources

Resource	Produced By	Used For
Consumer Goods (CG)	Industrial Districts (Civilian mode)	Science, unity, administration, pop upkeep. If you run out, pops are unhappy.
Alloys	Industrial Districts (Foundry mode)	Ships, starbases, megastructures. The most important military resource.

Tier 3: Strategic Resources

Resource	Produced By	Used For
Unity	Administrative buildings, traditions	Unlocking traditions (your empire's talent tree) and edicts
Research	Research labs (Physics, Society, Engineering)	Unlocking technology. Each type is separate.
Influence	Factions, first-contact, rivalries	Claims, diplomatic agreements, edicts, building starbases. The slowest resource.

The golden rule of Stellaris economics: If you're running a deficit, you can fix it by reallocating pops. Pause the game, check your resource screen (top bar), and move pops from surplus resources to deficit ones.

Understanding Planets

Planets are the **engine of your entire economy**. Every resource comes from a planet.

Districts vs Buildings

- **Districts** — large slots that provide basic jobs (generator/mining/agriculture). City districts provide housing and unlock building slots.
- **Buildings** — smaller slots that provide advanced jobs (researchers, administrators, alloy workers). Unlocked by city districts and technology.

Jobs & Pops

Each district and building creates **jobs**. Your **pops** (population units) fill these jobs. An employed pop produces resources. An unemployed pop is unhappy and can migrate.

The pop pipeline: Pop grows → Pop needs a job → Job produces → Resources fuel empire

Planet Specialization

Once you have 5+ pops on a planet, you can set its **designation**. This gives a production bonus to that planet's primary job type.

- **Generator World** — energy production +25%
- **Mining World** — mineral production +25%
- **Forge World** — alloy production +25%
- **Factory World** — consumer goods +25%
- **Tech World** — research +15%
- **Urban World** — trade value +20%, housing +15%
- **Rural World** — all basic resource jobs +10%

Tip: Don't mix and match on one planet. Specialize each planet for one resource type.

The First 30 Years — What You Actually Do

Year 1–5: Exploration Phase

1. **Pause immediately.** Look at your homeworld. Queue up a mix of districts and buildings.
2. **Build your first science ship** (if you didn't start with two). Set both to "Survey" in different directions.
3. **Build a construction ship.** Start building starbases in adjacent systems to claim territory.
4. **Build 2-3 more science ships** as your economy allows. Exploration is the most important early activity.

Year 5–20: Expansion Phase

1. Identify **chokepoints** — systems where your territory naturally narrows. Build starbases there.
2. Start your **first colony** — look for a planet with high habitability (green = 80%, yellow = 60%).
3. Keep surveying. **Anomalies** are the best source of early game rewards.
4. **Meet neighbors.** Send an envoy to improve relations with anyone who isn't immediately hostile.

Year 20–30: Consolidation Phase

1. Your first colony should be self-sufficient by now. Start a **second colony**.
2. Build your **first military fleet** — 20-30 corvettes is enough to deter early aggression.
3. Research **society techs** that unlock more starbases and colonies.
4. Pick a **tradition tree** — Discovery (science) or Expansion (territory) are strong early picks.

Understanding War

War in Stellaris is **not like other strategy games**. Here's what you need to know:

- **You need a Casus Belli (CB)** to declare war. Claims on enemy systems (costs influence) give you a CB.
- **War Exhaustion** builds over time as you fight. At 100%, you are forced into a status quo peace.
- **Taking systems** requires occupying the planet in that system with armies.
- **Armies** are built separately from fleets. They land on planets to conquer them.
- The **ship designer** lets you customize ships. Auto-design is fine for beginners.
- **Fleet capacity** limits how many ships you can have before paying extra upkeep. Starbases with anchorages increase it.
- **Naval capacity** = 10 + anchorage slots + technology. A fleet of 20 corvettes is ~40 naval capacity.

Victory — What Are You Playing For?

Stellaris has several **victory conditions** — or you can ignore them entirely and set your own goals.

Victory Type	What You Need To Do	Difficulty
Domination	Own or vassalize 60% of all colonizable planets	Hard — lots of war required
Federation	Lead a federation that controls 60% of all colonizable planets	Medium — diplomatic approach
Supremacy	Be the sole galactic power (every other empire is your subject or dead)	Very Hard
Score	Have the highest score by the victory year (2500 default)	Passive — just play well
Crisis	Defeat the end-game crisis (Unbidden, Contingency, or Prethoryn Swarm)	This happens regardless — it's not a victory type, but it feels like one

Recommended goal for your first game: "Explore, make friends, survive until the end-game crisis, and try to defeat it." Don't worry about formal victory.

Things the Game Doesn't Tell You

These are critical things Stellaris never explains:

1. **Pause is your best friend.** Pause every time you get a notification, a popup, or need to think. There's no penalty for pausing.
2. **Survey everything.** Every system in explored space. Anomalies and dig sites are your primary source of early rewards.
3. **Don't neglect your fleet.** Even as a pacifist, you need a fleet. AI empires consider fleet power when deciding whether to attack.
4. **Factions matter.** Keep your largest faction happy (+20% resource output) — check the Factions tab and adopt policies that please them.
5. **Sprawl is a soft cap, not a hard one.** Going over your administrative capacity gives a tech/unity penalty — but expanding is usually worth it anyway.
6. **Trade value is collected by starbases.** Your trade route network matters. Piracy spawns on unpatched trade routes.
7. **Sectors are automatic.** When you have too many planets, they auto-assign to sectors. You can set sector focus (economy, military, etc.).

8. **First contact takes time.** When you encounter a new alien empire, it takes months to establish communications. You can speed this up with envoys.
9. **Relics and archaeology.** Dig sites appear on surveyed planets. They tell stories and give powerful rewards. Always do them.
10. **The crisis is real.** Around 2400, one of three end-game crises will spawn. You need a fleet of 200K+ power (or more) to face it. Prepare.

DLC Features You Should Know About

Since you have all DLC, here's what each major expansion adds to your game:

DLC	What It Adds	Impact on Gameplay
Utopia	Megastructures, ascension paths (Psionic/Genetic/Synthetic), habitats, unity ambitions	Essential. Ascension paths define your late-game identity.
Apocalypse	Colossus (planet-killers), titans, marauders, the Great Khan	War becomes more dramatic. The Khan is a mid-game crisis.
Megacorp	Megacorporation authority, branch offices, ecumenopolis, the Caravaneers, slave market	Adds economic victory path.
Synthetic Dawn	Machine intelligence empires, rogue servitors, determined exterminators	Adds a major empire type. AI rebellions can happen.
Federations	Expanded federations (5 types), galactic community, origins, juggernauts	Diplomatic play is now much deeper.
Nemesis	Become the Crisis, espionage system, custodian/galactic emperor	You can become the villain. Espionage adds covert options.
Overlord	New vassal types, auto-resettlement, mercenary enclaves, orbital rings	Vassal management is now a powerful mechanic.
Paragons	Reworked leader system with unique paragon leaders	Leaders are now more interesting and personal.
Cosmogogenesis	Late-game crisis origin, new fallen empire mechanics	End-game content expansion.
Grand Archive	New archaeological content, relic collection, precursor overhaul	More story content and collectibles.

Next Steps

Once you understand these fundamentals, proceed to [Modlist Setup](#) to prepare your modded environment.

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Modlist Setup

This guide walks you through installing and configuring **Mod Organizer 2 (MO2)** to manage your Stellaris mods with version locking.

Why Mod Organizer 2?

- **Version locking** — stop auto-updates from breaking your campaign
- **Profiles** — separate mod sets for different playthroughs
- **Virtual filesystem** — your Stellaris install stays clean
- **Visual separators** — color-coded categories for easy management

Installation

Prerequisites

- Stellaris installed via Steam
- Windows 10 or later

Step 1: Download Mod Organizer 2

[Download MO2 from GitHub](https://github.com/ModOrganizer2/modorganizer/releases) (https://github.com/ModOrganizer2/modorganizer/releases) (latest stable release).

Install to a location outside Program Files to avoid permission issues — e.g., `C:\Games\Mod Organizer 2`.

Step 2: Configure for Stellaris

1. Launch MO2. It will ask for a game — select **Stellaris**.
2. If Stellaris isn't in the list, manually point MO2 to your Stellaris executable (e.g., `C:\Program Files (x86)\Steam\steamapps\common\Stellaris\stellaris.exe`).
3. MO2 will create a mod directory. Set it to a location with enough space.

Step 3: Download Mods

From Steam Workshop: 1. Subscribe to mods on Steam Workshop. 2. Launch MO2 — it will detect Workshop downloads. 3. Enable each mod in the left panel. MO2 manages load order.

From other sources (GitHub, Discord, Paradox Mods): 1. Download the mod archive. 2. Drag the folder into MO2's download tab, or manually place it in your MO2 mod directory.

Step 4: Version Locking

1. In MO2, right-click a mod in the left panel.
2. Select **Ignore Updates** to prevent Steam from auto-updating it.
3. For manual mods, keep a backup of the original archive.

Step 5: Create a Profile

1. Click the profile dropdown in MO2's top bar.
2. Select **Manage Profiles** → **Create New**.
3. Name it (e.g., "Modded 2026 v1"). This isolates your mod set from vanilla.

Load Order Basics

Mods lower in the left panel override mods higher up. General ordering:

1. Bugfixes
2. Audio
3. UI / HUD
4. Graphics
5. AI & Diplomacy
6. Economy & Automation
7. Warfare & Ships
8. Technology
9. Events & Story
10. Origins & Civics
11. Species, Genetics & Portraits
12. Galaxy & Setup

See [Load Order](#) for the detailed rules and separator definitions.

Handling Stellaris Version Updates

When Stellaris updates (major or minor), most mods will break until their authors update them. Never update Stellaris mid-campaign.

Checking Your Version

In Steam, right-click Stellaris → **Properties** → **Betas** tab. The current stable version is shown there.

Reverting to a Previous Version

If an update breaks your setup:

1. Right-click Stellaris in Steam → **Properties** → **Betas**
2. Select the version your guide was built for (e.g., 3.12 – "Andromeda")
3. Steam will downgrade the game
4. Mods tied to that version will work again

Older versions remain available on Steam indefinitely — Paradox doesn't remove them. Each version is tagged with a name (e.g., "Andromeda", "Bermuda", "Cepheus").

Version Matching

This guide targets **Stellaris 4.4.6 "Nomads"**. Every modlist entry must be confirmed compatible with 4.4.x before being added. Check the [Paradox Patches wiki](https://stellaris.paradoxwikis.com/Patches) (<https://stellaris.paradoxwikis.com/Patches>) to verify the current version.

If a mod's Workshop page doesn't mention 4.4.x compatibility, check its last update date — if it predates the 4.4 release, it's incompatible.

Starting Fresh

When you're ready to move to a new Stellaris version:

1. Create a new MO2 profile
2. Update mods that have been patched
3. Replace mods that were abandoned
4. Update this guide's `VERSION` file
5. Start a new campaign

Next Steps

With MO2 set up, head to [The Modlist](#) to start choosing your mods.

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Wave 1: The Horizon Seekers

Difficulty: Beginner — Learn the game under the safest possible conditions with a powerful patron watching your back.

"Your species was discovered by an ancient, god-like civilization known as The Keepers. They uplifted you from your homeworld, guided your early development, and now watch over your fledgling empire from their ring world. To the galaxy, you are the favored children of the immortals — protected, privileged, and perhaps a little naive. Your patrons task you with mysterious missions and demand tribute, but their protection ensures no one dares attack you. One day, you may learn the truth behind their ancient purpose — and decide your own destiny."

Empire Build: The Horizon Seekers

Element	Choice	Why
Ethics	Fanatic Egalitarian + Materialist	Research bonus + faction happiness. Simple and strong.
Authority	Democratic	Elections teach you faction management. Mandates give bonus unity.
Origin	Scion (<i>Federations</i> DLC)	A Fallen Empire protects you. You can focus on learning instead of surviving.
Traits	Intelligent, Rapid Breeders, Adaptive, Traditional / Sedentary, Wasteful	Research + growth + versatility. Weak penalties that are easy to manage.
Civics	Technocracy + Meritocracy	Rulers produce research. Specialists are more productive. Simple, powerful synergy.

Mods to Install

Install **only** the mods tagged Wave 1+ from these categories:

Category	Why Now
Bugfixes	Foundation — fix broken game behavior. Install first.
Audio	Zero mechanical impact. Better music and ambience.
UI & HUD	Quality of life. Better tooltips, wider panels, tech tree browser.
Graphics	Prettier visuals. No gameplay changes, just looks better.

Do not install mods from any other category yet. Wave 1 is about learning vanilla Starlight with better UI and graphics. Adding AI, economy, warfare, or content mods will confuse what's "the game" vs "the mod."

Galaxy Settings

Setting	Value	Why
Galaxy Size	Medium (600 stars)	Enough variety without late-game lag
Galaxy Shape	Spiral 4-arm	Classic. Chokepoints are clear.
AI Empires	8	Enough for diplomacy, not overwhelming
Fallen Empires	2	Your patron is one of them. Adds flavor.
Marauders	1	Mid-game chaos. Good to experience.
Advanced AI Starts	0	Everyone starts equal. Fair.
Difficulty	Ensign	No AI bonuses. You learn on even footing.
AI Aggression	Normal	Default. No one will rush you.
Crisis Strength	1x	Standard. Your patron helps if things get dire.
Crisis Type	Random	Let fate decide.
Mid-Game Start Year	2300	Standard
End-Game Start Year	2400	Standard
Hyperlane Density	1x	Default. Chokepoints make defense easier.
Habitable Worlds	1x	Default
Empire Placement	Random	Embrace the unknown.
Guaranteed Habitable Worlds	2	Essential for early expansion

Campaign Goal

"The Science Victory" — Explore the galaxy, make friends, out-research everyone, and survive until the end-game crisis. Don't worry about formal victory conditions. Your goal is to reach the end-game with a stable, prosperous empire.

What You'll Learn

By the end of this wave, you should understand:

- **Economy basics** — How districts, buildings, jobs, and pops create resources. How to read the resource bar and fix deficits.
- **Exploration** — Surveying, anomalies, dig sites, first contact. Why science ships are the most important ships.
- **Planets** — How to specialize planets, manage pops, and avoid unemployment.
- **Diplomacy** — Envoys, improving relations, non-aggression pacts, research agreements, embassies.
- **Basic research** — How the tech tree works, picking relevant techs, managing researchers.
- **Your patron** — How the Scion origin works, tribute demands, patron missions, the eventual succession war.

Walkthrough Milestones

Years 1–10: First Steps

1. **Pause immediately.** Queue 2 city districts, 1 industrial district, 1 research lab.
2. Build 2 more science ships (total 3). Survey in different directions.
3. Build a construction ship. Claim adjacent systems.
4. Queue 5 more corvettes. You're protected by your patron, but a fleet helps.
5. When you find 80%+ habitable planets, queue colony ships.

Years 10–30: Expansion Under Protection

1. Focus on chokepoints. Your patron protects you from invasion, so expand greedily.
2. Your first colony should be self-sufficient by year 15. Start a second by year 20.
3. Keep surveying. Anomalies are your best source of early rewards.
4. Pick Discovery tradition first (faster research + anomaly discovery).
5. **Your patron will demand tribute.** Pay it. The protection is worth it.

Years 30–100: The Middle Game

1. You should have 3–5 colonies. Specialize each one.
2. Join the Galactic Community when it forms. Vote on resolutions.
3. Build a federation with friendly neighbors.
4. Your patron will eventually give you a **succession war** mission. This is your chance to become independent. Prepare a fleet.
5. Keep research at max. Your goal is tech superiority.

Years 100–150: Late Game Preparation

1. You should be independent by now (or still under your patron). Either way, build tall.
2. Start megastructure projects (Science Nexus, Dyson Sphere) if you can.
3. Prepare for the end-game crisis. You need a fleet of 100K+ power.
4. Your patron's protection means you face less threat than normal — use this to tech up.

Years 150+: End-Game

1. The crisis will arrive around 2400. Meet it with your fleet.
2. Even if you lose, you learned. That's the point of Wave 1.

Graduation Criteria

You're ready for [Wave 2](#) when you can:

- Reach year 2280 with a **stable positive economy** in all basic resources
- Understand **planet specialization** (not mixing research and industry on the same planet)
- Successfully manage **first contact** and maintain at least one diplomatic agreement
- Build and maintain a **fleet** at or near your naval cap
- Complete the **Scion origin chain** (become independent or choose to serve)
- **Never used the emergency resources** (market, favors) to fix a spiraling deficit



Need more practice?



Play the wave again with a different Scion build. Try a spiritualist variant or a different authority type. The more comfortable you are with the basics, the more Wave 2 will teach you.

Next Wave Preview

In **Wave 2: The Eternal Legion**, you'll play as a militaristic empire on a relic world. You'll learn war, conquest, vassal management, and fleet combat — with gameplay mods that make the AI smarter and combat deeper. The training wheels come off.

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Wave 2: The Eternal Legion

Difficulty: Intermediate — You know the basics. Now learn war, conquest, and how to manage an empire built on strength.

"Your people are the inheritors of a long-dead empire whose relic cities still pierce the sky of your homeworld. The spires of the Ancients are a constant reminder of what was lost — and what could be reclaimed. Your society is built on a single creed: strength is the measure of worth. The weak serve, the strong lead, and the galaxy belongs to those who take it. The Ecumenopolis that sleeps beneath your feet whispers of a glory you were born to restore."

Empire Build: The Eternal Legion

Element	Choice	Why
Ethics	Authoritarian + Militarist + Spiritualist	Stratified society supports conquest. Military bonuses. Unity for traditions.
Authority	Imperial	Stable leadership. One ruler for 50+ years. No elections to distract you.
Origin	Remnants (<i>Federations</i> DLC)	Start on a relic world. Mid-game ecumenopolis potential. Unique archaeology chain.
Traits	Strong, Enduring, Industrious, Intelligent / Sedentary, Wasteful	Army + worker + research bonuses. Long-lived leaders. Same manageable penalties.
Civics	Distinguished Admiralty + Mining Guilds	+10% fire rate for your fleets. Miners produce bonus alloys. War-ready from day one.

Mods to Install

Keep **all Wave 1 mods** active. Add mods tagged **Wave 2+** from these categories:

Category	Why Now
AI & Diplomacy	Smarter AI empires that actually challenge you. Better diplomacy mods for vassal play.
Economy & Automation	Better sector AI, auto-colonization, auto-resettlement. You have more planets now — automation helps.
Warfare & Ships	New ship classes, weapon balances, fleet formations. War is now tactical, not just numerical.

Do not install Technology, Events, Origins, Species, or Galaxy mods yet. Those are for Wave 3. The gameplay mods here change *how* the game plays — the Wave 3 mods add *new content*. Learn the changed systems first.

Setting Up Your MO2 Profile

Create a new MO2 profile called "**Wave 2: The Eternal Legion**" with your Wave 1 mods plus the new Wave 2+ mods enabled. See [Modlist Setup](#) for profile instructions.

Galaxy Settings

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Wave 3: The Unshackled

Difficulty: Expert — You start as a rebellious vassal with zero guarantees. Every advantage is earned.

"Your species was conquered before they reached the stars. For generations, your people were slaves and second-class citizens in your own home system, ruled by a technologically superior alien empire. But the shackles are broken now. In a desperate uprising, your ancestors seized a fleet, liberated your homeworld, and declared independence. The galaxy sees you as upstarts, rebels, an inconvenience to be crushed. They are wrong. You have learned the secrets of your former masters. You know their weaknesses. And you will never be enslaved again."

Empire Build: The Unshackled

Element	Choice	Why
Ethics	Fanatic Militarist + Materialist	Military focus + tech advantage. You need both to survive.
Authority	Oligarchic (Council of Fleet Captains)	The captains who led the uprising now lead the empire. Fits the narrative.
Origin	Payback (First Contact DLC)	Start as a rebellious vassal. The hardest start. Fight your former overlord for freedom.
Traits	Natural Engineers, Strong, Adaptive, Enduring / Sedentary, Unruly	Tech + army + adaptability. You'll be colonizing aggressively. Unruly fits the rebel narrative.
Civics	Distinguished Admiralty + Nationalistic Zeal	+10% fire rate. Rivalry bonuses. Higher claim influence. Built for revenge.

Mods to Install

Enable **every mod in the modlist**. This is the full experience. Add mods tagged **Wave 3** from these categories:

Category	Why Now
Technology	Expanded tech trees, rare techs, new repeatables. More toys for your war machine.
Events & Story	New anomalies, archaeology, leviathans. The galaxy is richer and more dangerous.
Origins & Civics	More empire customization for future playthroughs. Others will have them too.
Species & Genetics	New traits, genetic engineering, cross-species mechanics.
Galaxy & Setup	More planet types, galaxy shapes, starting options. The sandbox expands.

Setting Up Your MO2 Profile

Create a new MO2 profile called **"Wave 3: The Unshackled"** with every mod enabled. See [Modlist Setup](#) for profile instructions.

Galaxy Settings

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Bugfixes

Mods that fix base-game bugs and oversights without adding new content. These are the foundation — install these first, they should be at the top of your load order.

Current Status

No bugfix mods are confirmed compatible with **Stellaris 4.4.6 "Nomads"** at this time. The comprehensive bugfix mods from earlier versions (3.x) have not been updated for 4.4.

To add bugfix mods: Search the [Steam Workshop](https://steamcommunity.com/app/281990/workshop/) for the **Fixes** tag, sorted by most popular. Verify compatibility with 4.4.x before adding. Follow the rules in [Modlist Setup](#) for version-locking.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes

Installation Notes

- **Version-lock all bugfix mods** in MO2. These are the most likely to be silently broken by a game update.
- Bugfix mods should be **first in your load order** — nothing should override a bugfix.
- Mod authors typically update within 1-3 weeks of a Stellaris patch. Until then, keep your game version locked to the previous release.

How to Add More

Browse the Steam Workshop with the **Fixes** tag. When adding a bugfix mod, verify it: 1. Doesn't add new content (pure fixes only) 2. Is compatible with **4.4.x** specifically 3. Lists its fix changelog so you know what's being patched 4. Is maintained by an active author

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Audio

Music, ambient soundscapes, sound effects, and voice-over improvements.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes

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UI & HUD

Interface improvements, tooltips, informative panels, and quality-of-life UI mods.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes
UI Overhaul Dynamic (https://steamcommunity.com/sharedfiles/filedetails/?id=1623423360)	Steam Workshop	No	1+	Dynamic resolution UI that adapts to any screen size. Wider windows, bigger lists, new planet/ship/fleet views, in-game tech tree. Tailored for 1080p–1440p; 4K users can scale to 2.0. Ironman-compatible.
UI Overhaul Dynamic - Dark UI (https://steamcommunity.com/sharedfiles/filedetails/?id=1993018111)	Steam Workshop	No	1+	Dark-style reskin of UI Overhaul Dynamic's graphics. Requires the main mod. Also works alongside other UIOD submods. Ironman-compatible.

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Graphics

Visual enhancements — textures, lighting, ships, backgrounds, UI art.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes

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AI & Diplomacy

AI behavior improvements, smarter empire management, diplomacy overhauls, federation and galactic community enhancements.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes

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Economy & Automation

Resource balance, job management, sector AI, auto-colonization, auto-resettlement, and planetary automation improvements.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes

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Warfare & Ships

Combat mechanics, new ship classes and sections, weapon balance, fleet formations, and military starbase improvements.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes

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Technology

Expanded tech trees, new repeatable technologies, rare tech discoveries, and tech balance adjustments.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes

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Events & Story

New anomalies, archaeological sites, event chains, leviathans, precursors, and narrative content.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes

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Origins & Civics

New origins, government civics, authority types, and empire creation options.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes

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Species, Genetics & Portraits

Mods related to species traits, genetic engineering, hybridization, portrait packs, namelists, and cross-species mechanics.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes

Performance Warning

Some genetics and pop mods can cause significant late-game lag due to pop multiplication and trait calculation. Where possible, notes on performance impact are included.

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Galaxy & Setup

Mods that expand galaxy generation, starting options, planetary diversity, hyperlane density, and game rules.

Mod	Source	Version-Locked	Wave	Notes

What to Look For

- **Galaxy size** — larger galaxy options, more star types
- **Hyperlane density** — custom density options for more/less connectivity
- **Planetary diversity** — more planet types, modifiers, classes
- **Starting options** — additional game rules, sliders, galaxy shapes
- **Precursor diversity** — more precursor civilizations and backstories

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Load Order

Proper load order is critical for a stable modded Stellaris experience. This page explains how to arrange your mods in MO2.

General Rules

Mods lower in the left **override** mods higher up. The hierarchy should be:

- | | |
|-----------------------------------|---|
| 1. Bugfixes | (fix game bugs, no content changes) |
| 2. Audio | (music, ambience, sound effects) |
| 3. UI / HUD | (interface, tooltips, icons) |
| 4. Graphics | (visuals, textures, lighting, portraits) |
| 5. AI & Diplomacy | (AI behavior, diplomacy, federations) |
| 6. Economy & Automation | (resources, jobs, sectors, auto-management) |
| 7. Warfare & Ships | (combat, ship classes, fleet mechanics) |
| 8. Technology | (tech tree, repeatables, rare tech) |
| 9. Events & Story | (anomalies, archaeology, leviathans) |
| 10. Origins & Civics | (starting options, government types) |
| 11. Species, Genetics & Portraits | (traits, genetics, portrait packs) |
| 12. Galaxy & Setup | (galaxy size, hyperlanes, planet diversity) |

Within each category, mods should be ordered from **foundational** (changes core mechanics) to **additive** (adds new things).

MO2 Separators

MO2 supports visual separators in the left mod list. Use the `mo2-separators.json` file in this repo to import color-coded category separators.

Importing Separators

1. In MO2, click the wrench icon (settings) → **Separators**.
2. Click **Import** and select `mo2-separators.json`.

Each category has a distinct color gradient for quick visual identification.

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Starting a Modded Game

This page is a general reference for empire creation and galaxy settings. For the full guided experience, follow [The Waves](#) in order — each wave prescribes a specific empire, mod set, and difficulty.

This page is your **pre-flight checklist**. Read it alongside the game as you create your first modded empire.

Step 1: Launch Through MO2

1. Open Mod Organizer 2.
2. Select your modded profile from the dropdown.
3. Ensure all mods are checked in the left panel and in the correct order (see [Load Order](#)).
4. Click **Run** — this launches Stellaris through the Paradox Launcher with your mods active.

In the Paradox Launcher, verify your playset shows the expected number of mods. If a mod is missing, exit and check it's enabled in MO2.

Step 2: Choose Your Empire

Ethics — Pick a Triad

Pick **three ethics** that work together. Here are tested beginner combos:

Combo	Name	Playstyle
Egalitarian + Materialist + Xenophile	"The Friendly Scientists"	Diplomacy + tech rush. Make friends, out-research everyone, win through Federation victory
Authoritarian + Militarist + Spiritualist	"The Divine Empire"	Conquest + unity. Strong leader, strong military, use traditions to power through
Fanatic Materialist + Egalitarian	"The Meritocracy"	Tech rush. Two points in Materialist, one in Egalitarian. Fastest research, robot workers, synthetic ascension later

Gestalt Consciousness: Skip for your first game. Hive minds and machine intelligences are mechanically different — no trade, no factions, no diplomacy in the traditional sense. Play them on run 2.

Authority — Pick One

Authority	Best For	Why
Democratic	Egalitarian empires	Mandates give bonus unity. Elections keep you engaged
Oligarchic	Materialist empires	More control over leader selection. Good for tech builds
Imperial	Authoritarian empires	Stable. Heirs mean no leadership gap. One ruler for 50+ years

Recommended: **Democratic** if Egalitarian, **Imperial** if Authoritarian.

Origin — Pick One

Origin	Best Empire Type	What to Expect
Prosperous Unification	Any	Strong start. More pops, developed homeworld. No surprises. Best for a first run.
Mechanist	Materialist	Early robots means bonus production. You'll have robot pops working basic jobs while organics do skilled work.
Syncretic Evolution	Authoritarian	Two species. Your main species is intelligent/scholarly, the secondary is strong/rapid breeding. The workers work, the thinkers think.
Lost Colony	Any	Sol is out there somewhere. Adds roleplay and a narrative hook.
Remnants	Any	Start on a relic world (unlocks ecumenopolis later). Strong mid-game payoff.
Galactic Doorstep	Any	A mysterious gateway in your home system. Early gateway access is great for mobility.

Species Traits — Build for Your Goal

If your goal is research (recommended): - **Intelligent** (+2 trait points) — +10% research speed - **Rapid Breeders** (+2) — +10% pop growth - **Adaptive** (+2) — +10% habitability - **Traditional** (+1) — +10% unity - **Sedentary** (-1) — -15% migration speed (weak penalty, free point) - **Wasteful** (-1) — +10% consumer goods upkeep (manageable penalty)

Total: +5 cost, -2 refund = **3 points used** (of your typical 3–5 budget). Clean, focused, no newbie traps.

If your goal is conquest: - **Strong** (+2) — +5% army damage, +2.5% worker output - **Enduring** (+1) — +20 leader lifespan - **Industrious** (+2) — +15% mineral output - **Intelligent** (+2) — always good - **Sedentary** (-1), **Wasteful** (-1) — same refunds

Civics — Pick Two

Pick civics that reinforce your chosen playstyle:

Goal	Civic 1	Civic 2
Research	Technocracy (rulers produce research)	Meritocracy (+10% specialist output)
Expansion	Mining Guilds (miners produce alloys)	Functional Architecture (cheaper buildings, +1 slot)
Diplomacy	Parliamentary System (+influence from factions)	Diplomatic Corps (+2 envoys)
Conquest	Distinguished Admiralty (+10% fire rate)	Warrior Culture (+20% army damage, entertainment replaces consumer goods)

Step 3: Set Your Galaxy

These settings give a fun, balanced first modded game:

Setting	Recommendation	Why
Galaxy Size	Medium (600–800 stars)	Large enough for exploration and variety, small enough that mid-game isn't 5 FPS
Galaxy Shape	Spiral 4-arm	Classic layout. You're on one arm, neighbors on others. Chokepoints are clear.
AI Empires	8	Enough for diplomatic variety, not so many that you're boxed in
Fallen Empires	2	Ancient sleeping giants. They wake up late-game and sometimes have cool quests.
Marauders	1	Mid-game raiders. They attack everyone, creating chaos. Fun.
Advanced AI Starts	3	Some AI empires start ahead. Gives you a mid-game rival to catch up to.
Difficulty	Ensign	Fair. No AI bonuses. You'll learn the game on equal footing.
AI Aggressiveness	Normal	Default.
Crisis Strength	1x (default)	The end-game crisis is challenging but beatable on your first run.
Crisis Type	Random	Let fate decide.
Mid-Game Start Year	2300	Standard. The Khan or other mid-game events start here.
End-Game Start Year	2400	Standard. The crisis arrives around this time.
Victory Year	2500	Standard. You'll either win or die horribly by now.
Hyperlane Density	1x	Default. Fewer hyperlanes = more chokepoints, easier to defend.

Habitable Worlds	1x	Default. Too many worlds = micro-nightmare. Too few = slow growth.
Empire Placement	Random	Embrace the chaos.
Guaranteed Habitable Worlds	2	You'll have 2 habitable planets near your start. Essential for early expansion.

Step 4: Set a Campaign Goal

Before you unpause, decide what you want this campaign to be about.

Campaign Goal	Playstyle	Suggested Setup
"The Science Victory"	Tall + diplomatic. Make friends, build research labs, win through technology and a federation.	Fanatic Materialist + Egalitarian. Technocracy + Meritocracy. Prosperous Unification.
"Galactic Conqueror"	Wide + aggressive. Expand fast, build a big fleet, conquer neighbors.	Authoritarian + Militarist. Distinguished Admiralty + Mining Guilds. Prosperous Unification.
"Space Switzerland"	Peaceful tall. One sector, megastructures, trade. Win through economy.	Egalitarian + Xenophile + Pacifist. Merchant Guilds + Diplomatic Corps. Remnants or Prosperous Unification.
"Just Explore"	No formal goal. Survey everything, do every anomaly, roleplay your species.	Any. The game is your sandbox.

Step 5: The First 10 Years – Checklist

When you unpause, do this:

1. **Pause immediately.** Queue 2 city districts, 1 industrial district, and 1 research lab on your homeworld.
2. **Build 2 more science ships** (total 3). Set them all to survey in different directions.
3. **Build a construction ship** and start building starbases in adjacent systems to claim territory.
4. **Queue another 2-3 corvettes** so your starting fleet isn't alone.

5. **Unpause at fastest speed.** Keep an eye on popups. Pause whenever something interesting happens.
6. **When you find habitable planets** (80%+ habitability), queue a colony ship.
7. **When you meet neighbors,** send an envoy to improve relations. Don't make enemies early.

After 10 years, you should have: - 3+ science ships actively surveying - 5–10 star systems claimed - 1 colony ship built or en route - 10–15 corvettes in your fleet - 2–3 anomalies solved

Step 6: Things to Check Before You Unpause for Real

- Your **economy is positive** in all basic resources. If it's not, pause and fix it.
- Your **fleet is at or near capacity** — build up to your naval cap.
- You have **at least one construction ship** idle — you'll need it for starbases.
- Your **science ships have crew** — they automatically staff when built.
- Mod-specific popups: **read them.** Some mods start with configuration events.

Common First-Game Mistakes to Avoid

1. **Building too many labs too fast** — researchers need consumer goods. If you build them before you have CG income, your economy collapses.
2. **Neglecting alloys** — you can't build ships or expand starbases without alloys. Keep at least one industrial district on foundry mode.
3. **Not surveying** — unexplored space is wasted potential. Keep every science ship busy.
4. **Ignoring factions** — happy factions give bonuses. Check the Factions tab every 10-20 years.
5. **Over-expanding** — more systems = more tech/unity cost. Expand to choke points, then develop what you have.
6. **Saving influence** — influence has a cap (usually 1000). If you're capped, spend it on edicts, claims, or diplomatic agreements.
7. **Forgetting armies** — you can't conquer a planet without armies. Build a few assault armies before any war.

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Performance

Work in progress. This page will document empirical performance benchmarks comparing vanilla vs. modded Stellaris.

Methodology

- **Hardware:** [Your specs here]
- **Settings:** 1920x1080, Ultra quality, Fastest galaxy
- **Measurement tool:** FPS counter (Steam overlay), task manager for load times
- **Save:** 100-year autosave from a standard game

Benchmark Results

Scenario	FPS (min/avg)	Load Time	Notes
Vanilla	—	—	Baseline
All mods	—	—	Full modlist
Graphics mods only	—	—	Visual comparison
Gameplay mods only	—	—	Gameplay comparison

Known Performance Impacts

- **Graphics mods:** High-res textures and lighting overhauls can cost 5-15 FPS depending on GPU
- **Pop-heavy mods:** Mods that add many new pops or jobs will slow late-game
- **UI mods:** Minimal to no impact
- **Galaxy size mods:** Larger galaxies increase load times and late-game lag

Tips for Better Performance

- Reduce galaxy size from Medium to Small

- Lower hyperlane density
- Set planet habitability to lower values (fewer colonization targets)
- Disable xeno-compatibility if it's in your modlist (notorious for pop bloat)
- Use the "Pop Scaling" option in Stellaris game settings

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Missing Mods (Research)

Research & planning file. Mods that don't exist yet but would complete the modlist vision. These are candidates for custom development.

Mod Idea	Category	Why It's Needed	Priority	Notes

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Appendix

Glossary

Term	Definition
Origin	Your empire's starting condition and backstory
Hyperlane	The travel routes between star systems
Starbase	Your control point in each system; allows ship building and defense
Pop	Population unit on a planet; each pop works a job
District	Planet area type (Energy, Mining, Agriculture, Industrial, City)
Building	Planet structure that provides advanced jobs
Megastructure	Large-scale construction project (Dyson Sphere, Matter Decompressor, etc.)
Crisis	End-game threat that emerges around 2400
Ascension Path	End-game tradition tree (Psionic, Genetic, or Synthetic)
Federation	Alliance of empires with shared rules and benefits
Galactic Community	Galactic-wide voting body that passes laws
Edict	Empire-wide modifier you activate with influence or unity

Troubleshooting

Game crashes on launch

- Disable all mods. Re-enable one by one to find the culprit.
- Check MO2's log for error messages.

- Verify Stellaris game files in Steam.

Mods not showing in game

- Ensure MO2 profile is correct.
- Make sure mods are enabled in the left panel.
- Check that the mod's game version matches your Stellaris version.

Performance issues

- See [Performance](#) for optimization tips.
- Disable graphics-intensive mods if late-game lag persists.

Save won't load

- You removed a mod that the save depends on. Re-enable it.
- A mod updated mid-campaign. Roll back to the previous version (MO2 version locking prevents this).

Credits

Mod Authors

All mods in this guide belong to their respective creators. Links to each mod's source are provided in the modlist sections.

Guide Tools

- [MkDocs](https://www.mkdocs.org/) (https://www.mkdocs.org/) — site generation
- [Material for MkDocs](https://squidfunk.github.io/mkdocs-material/) (https://squidfunk.github.io/mkdocs-material/) — theme
- [mkdocs-exporter](https://adrienbrignon.github.io/mkdocs-exporter/) (https://adrienbrignon.github.io/mkdocs-exporter/) — PDF export
- [Mod Organizer 2](https://github.com/ModOrganizer2/modorganizer) (https://github.com/ModOrganizer2/modorganizer) — mod management